

Georgia Institute of Technology

Large Paper Analysis:

In the Mood for Love

Josie Kwan

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Dr. Jason Woodworth-Hou

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Brain Eggert, in his analysis described Wong Kar-wai's *In the Mood for Love* as "a mood piece" that "adopts the structure of a memory". The film is a collection of Mo-wan's memories as much as it is a collection of Wong's memories of the Hong Kong he grew up in. This paper studies how *In the Mood for Love* acts as a time capsule by recreating and preserving this era in Hong Kong's history. It also explores how Wong's stylistic choices in mise-en-scene and cinematography in *In the Mood for Love* created a new aesthetic that pushed Hong Kong cinema in a new direction and left a whole new genre of Hong Kong films in its wake. Lastly, this paper will look at how *In the Mood for Love* left a lasting impact on cinema, specifically in the blockbuster movie *Everything, Everywhere, All at Once*, Wong's aesthetic is recreated.

In the Mood for Love tells the story of neighbors Mrs. Chan (played by Maggie Cheung Man-yuk) and Mr. Chow (played by Tony Leung Chiu-wai) who slowly realize that their spouses are having an affair with each other. Connected by this secret and attempting to decode how it happened, the two form a deep bond that tragically cannot lead to anything as the two promise not to become like their unfaithful spouses. The framing of the movie emphasis' the protagonist helplessness. In every shot they are trapped. Boxed in cramped interiors.



Figure 1 Chow Mo-wan (Leung) and Su Li-zhen (Cheung) in taxi cab

Tight hallways. As well as being trapped by cultural factors, gossip, and fear of what would happen if others saw them together. Even when they are taking a taxi and are traveling through the streets of Hong Kong the camera is restricted to the interior or is looking through the back

window locking them in (fig. 1). Not once does the camera have an establishing shot of the roads of Hong Kong, or the apartment building they live in or the outside of the hotel building. What the camera does do is take on the role of a spectator and this is intentional as Wong states “we wanted to create the feeling that the audience was one of the neighbors.” (Bear 4). Adding to the idea that they are being watched and therefore cannot be with each other.

Another pattern that emerges is the blending of scenes and time. Later about midway through the film Mr. Chow gets an apartment to try to escape from the prying eyes of neighbors. There is a montage of scenes that play out to the haunting sound of the repeated string number, Yumeji’s theme (55:49). Mrs. Chan walks down a narrow hallway that has red curtains, a new place, she is dressed in red. Then cut followed by a slow pan to the right revealing first the back of a chair then see Mrs. Chan reflected in the mirror once then twice. The pan continues until the screen is black for a frame, then we see Mr. Chow eating. Then background unblurs and see Mrs. Chan sitting, we are still in the same room. Pan right, see the two together talking, camera is pointed at them, but red window’s blinds partial obstructs view. Cut Mrs. Chan in a different dress signifying time has passed. Camera looking over someone’s shoulder. The camera pans to the right, revealing it was looking at Mrs. Chan’s reflection as she stands behind Mr. Chow and now the mirror shows multiple images of Mr. Chow. Camera pans back left. This pattern continues for the rest of the montage with the strings in the background filling in the space as no audible dialogue is shared. With repeated camera pans and similar cuts, it is only in the details that one realizes that time is passing. Wong’s edits the movie in a way that makes each transition appear the same as if each scene is connected to each other. The audience must deduce which scenes are connected by paying attention to little details, much like how the two protagonists figure out that their spouses are having an affair.

This isn't the only way that Wong uses repetition. Throughout the film songs are repeated, creating an intense and specific atmosphere. The soundtrack is left playing in the audience's mind and is rooted in Wong's memories. For example, the inclusion of Nat King Cole's Spanish songs "Aquellos ojos verdes" and "Quizas, Quizas, Quizas" is in acknowledgement to the night-club scene which was dominated at the time by "Filipinos who often sang in Spanish." (Chayka). In addition, having a famous American singer, singing a Spanish song creates another layer of abstraction. These are two harshly different and almost contrasting cultures being blended much like how Hong Kong culture is a blend of East and West influences. While the butchering of the Spanish language captured in the recording is symbolic of inability of the two main characters being together. There are Mandarin and traditional Cantonese songs that represent Hong Kong in the 60's. However, the most notable number and most repeated is a string number is taken from a Japanese film "Yumeji" and is played a total of nine times and creates an almost theme song for the movie. Each time it plays we watch as the main characters dance around each other being pulled helplessly closer and closer together before being pulled apart again.



Figure 2 Repeated clock

Throughout the film, time moves in an elliptical fashion, halting and stuttering forwards. Often time is frozen much like the office clock that is repeatedly shown (fig. 2). Yet almost without us realizing it the time

passes and the character changes with it. Time passes and creeps up on us like the couples' feelings for each other.

In an interview with Liza Bear, Wong Jar-wai states that he always wanted to set a film in Hong Kong early 1960s because "I'm from that background, and I wanted to recreate that world." (Bear 3). That world being British Hong Kong, which was a vibrant blend of East and West. 1960's Hong Kong saw an influx of immigrants from China due to the CCP winning the Chinese Civil War in 1949 and the Cultural Revolution on the horizon. Wong, and his family along with countless others immigrants left their homes in China for Hong Kong bringing along with them their own traditions and customs. This is the backdrop of *In the Mood for Love*. This movie is as much about the two main characters and their love as it is about the city they reside in. Hong Kong 's identity on the surface is a love story of east meeting west, but underneath is a tragedy a clash between capitalism and communist, freedom and oppression, tradition and progress. This love affair sums up the era of culture and geopolitics that shaped Wong's life and many others. "Chan and Chow engage in waltzing restraint that curiously echoes the fraught dance of great powers around Hong Kong itself" (Sadashige 2). The future of Hong Kong remains uncertain, which the movie makes reference to with the hotel number being 2047 the year Hong Kong's agreement of continued sovereignty (one country two system) is set to expire. The abundance of ambiguity in the film mimics the uncertainty of Hong Kong.

A title slide that appears in towards the end of the movie reads, "That era has passed. Nothing that belonged to it exists anymore." And once you start to look for clues to what that era was, they show up everywhere. The distinct music, a new rice cooker made in Japan but not sold in Hong Kong, manual typewriters, Mrs. Chan's high necked Cheongsam dresses, Mr. Chow's slicked back hair. Then cultural how Mr. Chow can rent an apartment freely without question,

but Mrs. Chan is judged for being out so often. All the details that Wong makes the audience focus on tell of an era that is indeed long passed. An era that is preserved in both his memory and now in this movie.

Towards the end of the film there is a distinct break in style. A title card reads Cambodia, 1966, followed by documentary footage of Cambodia before its civil war. As the movie and characters move from Hong Kong, back to Singapore to Cambodia and the ruins of Angkor Wat (specifically Mr. Chow), we see both how the places they are in shape them as much as they shape the places they are in. While in Angkor Wat Mo-wan whispers a secret assumedly about Su into a hole, referencing back to a tradition that he told his friend Ping about. This move shows him both burying the past and saving it for all time. Here the camera moves freely not caged in by anything and instead sweeps through long establishing shots of the Angkor Wat temple and a lone monk. The movie ends in the year 1966 right before the Cambodia civil war where Angkor Wat and many other temples are destroyed, and the monks are killed. By ending the movie here Wong keeps with the trend of only subtly showing the geopolitical story that is unfolding in the background of these characters' lives. Emphasizing each person living in these countries has an important and detailed story that is often forgotten in the wake of large countries and their conflicts.

Wong shaped the genre of Hong Kong movies and cleared "a path for more casual, intimate, and atmospheric directors after him" (Chayka). A recent film that took inspiration from Wong's aesthetic was the film *Everything*,



Everywhere, All at Once. Directors Daniel Kwan, Daniel Scheinert paid homage to Wong Kar-wai as one of the alternate universes their main character, Evelyn, finds herself in she has a deep conversation with Waymond who in this life she did not run away with. Where they have this conversation is a rainy alley way that could've been the same one that Su and Mo-wan had multiple tense conversations in. The green filter and moody lighting mimic Wong's style specifically of the movie *In the Mood for Love*. (fig. 3). The parallel between the characters is also strong as in this *Everything, Everywhere, All at Once* in the universe that mimics *In the Mood for Love* Evelyn and Waymond love each other, but because of outside factors they are forced to stay apart. The only relationship they can have consist of longing glances and fleeting moments of pretend, dreaming of another world or life in which everything turns out well and they can be together. These are some of the quietest moments in the film that is action packed and that is again a reference to *In the Mood for Love* which is as much about what the character say as what they don't say.

In conclusion, Wong's movie *In the Mood for Love* tells the emotional story of two lovers not to be, draws on his own memories of Hong Kong transporting audiences back to an era long past. Much like how the main character buries his secret in the tree to be kept so too does this movie define and recreate that era of Hong Kong's unique history. His focus on details such as costuming and set design as well as unique cinematography helped create a distinct aesthetic that influenced many directors after him. The impact which can be seen in movies following it, in specific the Daniel's blockbuster film *Everything, Everywhere, All at Once*.

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